

Kerala Blasters in the next match, trailing 1-2 by the 77th minute.

Kuruniyan proved his worth once again after Molina turned to him to salvage the situation as an 80th-minute substitute.

The transformation was immediate. Ashique galvanised the flanks with his incisive runs and assisted Australian forward Jason Cummings to score the equaliser in the 86th minute (2-2).

With Mohun Bagan now finding its way back into the attacking third, thanks to Ashique's influence, the winning goal was all but inevitable. Mohun Bagan found the winner in injury time through a Rodriguez (**left, below**) pile-driver, completing Ashique's comeback mission.

The 27-year-old express winger is now waiting for national coach Manolo Márquez to recall him to the Indian team.

Amitabha Das Sharma

Back to old habits

The Kerala Blasters is known for firing coaches midway through the season. The latest in the line is Swede Mikael Stahre who was sacked the other day after the Blasters' poor run. The team had lost six of its last seven games and was down in the 10th spot with 11 points from 12 games when the Blasters management decided it was time for a change.

Stahre joins a long line of Blasters coaches who had to leave midway through the season, a list that includes Peter Taylor, Rene Meulenstein, David James, Kibu Vicuna. This time, the Blasters let go of their assistant coaches Bjorn Westrom and Frederico Pereira Morais too.

In their last game against Mohun Bagan, the current leader of the Indian Super League table, the Blasters let slip a 2-1 lead. Throwing away leads and losing games have often been the Blasters story this season. And Stahre was made to pay the price.

But Manjappada, the Blasters' famed fan club which has stood with the team through thick and thin, feels the move is unfair.

"Rather than taking responsibility for their own failures, they've chosen

to make a scapegoat of a coach who has given his all for the team," said Manjappada on its X handle.

"This move reeks of cowardice and a lack of accountability. The management's inept handling of the team's affairs, including poor transfers, and a lack of clear vision, are the real reasons behind our team's struggles."

By the way, the Blasters have the biggest fan base in the ISL. The fans pack the stadium during games in Kochi, which gives the KBFC a huge edge during home matches.

Until the new coach is announced, Tomasz Tchorz, the Blasters reserve team's head coach and head of youth development, and assistant coach T.G. Purushothaman will take over the responsibility of managing the first team. Incidentally, Ivan Vukomanovic, the previous coach, had stayed on for three years and had helped the team to the playoffs every year, even making the final in his first season with the club.

And the Serb was a big hit with the fans, being as popular as the team's biggest star during his stay in Kochi.

Stan Rayan

Home blues for Chennaiyin

East Bengal was already up against history ahead of its ISL away match against Chennaiyin FC. The Red and Gold Brigade had never defeated Chennaiyin at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in the ISL.

Also, East Bengal's lacklustre start

to the ISL season saw Carles Cuadrat's exit, and new coach Oscar Bruzon was under pressure to deliver results.

The circumstances were not too kind for Coyle either. Yet to win a home game this season, Chennaiyin was on a two-match losing streak. The stage was perfectly set leading up to the match.

As the Diary settled in the media tribune inside the Nehru Stadium, he could see a cluster of fans adorned in Red and Gold who had made the journey to Chennai.

Famed for its away support, it was no surprise that the small section of East Bengal fans was louder than the home crowd, which sounded meek at best.

Right from kick-off, Coyle's plan to isolate forward Dimitrios Diamantakos was evident, as the Greek striker was left stranded up top. On the other side, Chennaiyin's Daniel Chima Chukwu had a couple of chances but failed to capitalise against his former side. The first half saw the net remain undisturbed, and it was time for the managers to earn their money with their half-time team talks.

And it was Bruzon who won the tactical battle in the second 45. East Bengal opened the scoring against the run of play, with PV Vishnu finding the net in the 54th minute.

Jeakson Singh (**below**) thwarted any hopes of a Chennaiyin comeback with a screamer in the 84th minute to seal all three points.

Aneesh Dey

